

« I'm looking for an Olympic medal for India in golf »

KAPIL DEV

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From a humble beginning in rural Haryana to the pinnacle of world cricket, Kapil Dev has seen it all. But over nearly three decades, the captain of the 1983 World Cup-winning team has walked many miles to cover the distance from a curious golfer to the committed President of the Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI).

In this one-of-a-kind interview with *Sportstar*, Kapil reflects on his love for golf and his vision for the future of Indian golfers.

Can you recall your first impression of golf?

I recall it was in the early 1990s, when Sir Gary Sobers visited India for business and told me he wanted to play golf. I didn't know anything about the sport, so I called a friend

and told him that Gary wanted to play it in Delhi, and I didn't know whom to approach.

He said, "Don't worry, I'll just sign him in at the Delhi Golf Club." Since Sobers wasn't carrying his golf set, he needed one to play. At the Club he was asked whether he needed a set for a right-hander or a left-hander. Sobers said it didn't matter — any set would do. I was further confused.

Then they asked Sobers what his handicap was. He said it was two if he played right-handed and one if he played left-handed.

The man at the Club looked shocked! He thought he had heard it wrong. But soon the confusion was over.

On the appointed day, I took him to the Club and walked the course while he played. He was so good. I

admired his skill sets. He was truly the finest cricketing hero of our time. No cricketer was bigger than Sir Gary. He was given a cart and he played with two members of the club.

After a few years, once I stopped playing cricket in late 1994, a friend of mine, Karan Dubey, who played Ranji Trophy with me, said, "Let's play golf."

I said, "I don't want to. It's for old people. I still feel young. I want to stay away from people — I want to have time to myself."

But he insisted. I said, "There are a lot of people."

He said, "Just come. There won't be anyone on the course."

I practised for a few days at the Army course near Dhaula Kuan, and then, for the first time, I came to play at the Delhi Golf Club.